interior designer, an architect and a fashion designer. "My trajectory is not charted out by me. It has always been somebody else noticing the potential in me, and me rather naively or playfully saying, 'yeah, I'll try'." It helped, he says, that things were more relaxed in those days. "There was room for error and delays, people who commissioned me their projects had larger visions. It was more like a patron picking an artist and saying, I am behind you," he says.

5-STAR HOTELS WERE SOME OF PATEL'S FIRST PATRONS. IN 1984, HE OPENED ETCETERA, ONE OF INDIA'S FIRST LIFESTYLE STORES



Photographs by **ADITYA SINHA**

For someone who is regarded as having spearheaded the 'India Modern' design aesthetic, Patel says his definition of it keeps evolving "because design lives on the peripheries of life and socioeconomic changes reflect upon individual lives. That in turn affects design trends." Not wanting to conform to the labels being projected on us by the West, he stumbled upon his theory of 'essentialism'. "We cannot survive into stark opposites that the West may put onto us, such as minimalism and maximalism. India somehow lives in the grey space between those, because what is essential to one person is excess for another one and too little for another," he believes.

In 1999, much before the elite of Mumbai started looking at Alibaug as a holiday home destination, Patel shifted his base to the coastal city. In 2022, he also opened his eponymous 5,000 square feet furniture store in Alibaug. Up until the pandemic, the studio also housed The Dashrath Patel Museum, which they had to shut because of COVID.

He has also formed a collective called Alibaug Optimists "to differentiate ourselves from activists who oppose change". "[We are] optimists who are trying to fight for Alibaug's future against urbanisation," he says. Patel is concerned about the lack of infrastructure and is fighting to get the group's voices heard. Otherwise, the 72-year-old leads a "sattvic life", waking up early and spending his mornings doing yoga and taking long walks. "So, I require less Botox and don't complain of knee pain even at this age," he chuckles. As he champions the future of Alibaug and the 'India Modern' aesthetic, his life stands as a masterclass in designing with purpose. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The Turning Point *is on display at Nilaya Anthology, Mumbai, till Mar. 31*

The exhibition brings together artists from India and abroad to **interrogate how technology** reshapes identity, intimacy and everyday life



SWIM AGAINST THE TIDE
A still from the 'Groteskkbasiliskk! Mineral Mixtape', a video artwork by Mochu

Dimension Plus (Taiwan), Elsewhere in India (India), IIT Kanpur HIVE Lab (India), Leewardists (India) and Mochu (India). Workshops, curatorial walkthroughs and film screenings will be held as part of the exhibition. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

Are You Human? *at Khoj Studios (Jan. 30–Feb. 28) and DLF Avenue Mall (Jan. 30– Feb. 10), Delhi*